North Carolina, developed a leak during its airborne refueling. Before the bomber could make it back to base, the crew was forced to eject, and the plane broke apart in midair, releasing two live nuclear bombs. When one of the bombs hit the ground, the concussion caused an electrical spark that sent a firing signal. The four-megaton weapon did not detonate only because its fifth and last safety switch held in place, the other four fifty-cent safety switches having failed when they smashed on impact. Had the last safety switch similarly failed, the bomb would have been fully armed, and the firing signal would have set off a thermonuclear explosion on American territory.

North Korea almost certainly won't have nuclear bombers, but the bulk of its ground-based force will likely be dispersed onto mobile launchers, which pose their own set of problems. These road-mobile transporter erector launchers (TELs) are fitted onto large trucks that



Figure 1. North Korea's Nuclear Facilities. *Note: North Korea also deploys mobile-launched missiles and is developing submarine launches as well.*